

Day 4 — Element Sort (Hands-on Activity)

Module: Panchabhūta · **Band:** Middle · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

By the end of this lesson, students will classify at least 12 everyday objects by their dominant element and defend a classification where more than one element is present.

Materials

- Students bring their 3 home-objects from yesterday’s homework.
- ~5 mystery objects supplied by the teacher (suggested: a bicycle pump, a glass of milk, a magnifying glass, a small mirror, a sponge).
- 5 sorting trays / boxes / labelled areas on the floor — one per element.
- Worksheet (one per pair) — printable from [activities/activity-01-element-sort.md](#).

Vocabulary recap

No new terms today. Review *pr̥thvī*, *ap*, *tejas*, *vāyu*, *ākāśa* and the five tanmātras.

Lesson flow

Warm-up (5 min)

- Daily prompt: “Which element did you notice most yesterday?” — 2 students.
- Brief: today is a sorting day. We’ll see how messy the world really is when you try to put it in five boxes.

Core (10 min) — Demonstrate with one tricky object

- Hold up a glass of milk. “Where does this go?”
- Take 3 student answers.
- Then walk through it together:
 - It’s a *liquid* → *ap* (water-element).
 - But milk has *fat* (solid suspended particles) → some *pr̥thvī*.
 - It has *taste* (*rasa*) → tanmātra of water, confirms.
 - It has *smell* (*gandha*) → some earth-quality too.
 - You can *see* it (*rūpa*) → some fire-quality (form/colour).
- Conclusion: **most real objects are mixtures**. The exercise is to identify the *dominant* element while honestly naming the others present.

Activity (25 min) — Element Sort

Follow the full activity sheet ([activities/activity-01-element-sort.md](#)). Brief outline:

1. Students work in **pairs**.
2. Each pair places their 3 home-objects + 2 teacher-supplied objects on the right element tray. (5 objects per pair.)
3. For each object, they fill the worksheet table:
 - Object name
 - Dominant element
 - Other elements present (1–4 more)
 - Strongest tanmātra
4. **Gallery walk (5 min within the 25):** pairs visit two other pairs' trays and put a sticky note where they disagree, explaining briefly.

Wrap-up (5 min)

- Discussion question, open to the room: “Which object was the hardest to classify, and why?”
- Preview Day 5: a mid-module check + an extended reflection.

Student-facing content

(The activity sheet is the student-facing content — see [activities/activity-01-element-sort.md](#).)

Homework

- No new homework. (Spend the freed time finalising the project pair or topic — partners and projects are confirmed by Day 5.)

Differentiation

- **One tier up:** After sorting, pick the **single most “mixed”** object and write a paragraph explaining the proportions you’d assign each of the five elements within it.
- **One tier down:** If five categories feel hard, sort first into THREE — *pr̥thvī*, *ap*, *vāyu* — then come back and consider where *tejas* or *ākāśa* should be added.

Teacher notes

- This activity often surfaces interesting disagreements between students who classify the same object differently. **Don’t resolve the disagreements quickly** — let them argue it out. The reasoning is more important than the answer.
- A common dispute: where does a “balloon filled with air” go? *Vāyu* because the *content* is air? Or *pr̥thvī* because the *balloon material* is rubber (a solid)? Both are defensible — push students to articulate which one is “dominant.”
- Look for students who are insisting on a single rigid answer. They are missing the lesson — gently steer toward “and what’s the next-strongest element here?”
- Photograph any especially good or disputed sorting choices; reuse on Day 7 group discussion.

Citation(s) used in this lesson

- No new citations introduced. Review citations from Day 1–3.